

in the Valley, the UPA Government finds itself in a dilemma, which was further complicated by provocative posturing by politicians and hardliners in both regions. While the samiti has stridently struck a "nothing short of land" stance, the Valley-based politicians and separatists are dead opposed to cede "even an inch of land" on paper to Shri Amarnath Shrine which ironically was discovered by a Muslim shepherd more than a century ago.

The politics over the religious row has made strange bedfellows in the Valley where the National Conference (NC) and People's Democratic Party (PDP) are now supping with their arch enemy—the separatist lobby led by Hurriyat factions—on the land transfer issue. "There is an overwhelming perception in Kashmir that land transfer to the Shri Amarnath Shrine Board will

said samiti convener Leela Karan Sharma, an RSS old-timer. "The Kashmiri leaders' stand is a provocative challenge to the Hindus that they can't have a piece of land in the Valley for religious use on temporary basis," he added.

Not surprisingly, 'bham bham bhole' has become a rallying cry and temples are the nocturnal meeting points for planning and orchestrating street protests despite the curfew. "It's not a political agitation but a people's movement to force the Government to assuage the hurt Hindu sentiments and undo the step-motherly treatment meted out to Jammu in the past 60 years," said Om Parkash, a local businessman. The Army, called in

IN THE NAME OF GOD: The Shri Amarnath Yatra Sangharsh Samiti leaders at the all-party meeting



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undermine their special status under Article 370. We cannot wish away that perception," said PDP chief Mehbooba Mufti, conveniently forgetting that her party had agreed to the state cabinet's decision of transferring 100 acres of land to the board before it made a U-turn fearing that the consent could erode its Kashmiri constituency. Such crass display of political opportunism has stoked religious frenzy in Jammu, lending popular support to what is now being touted as the 'mother of all agitations'. "It is not just a land transfer issue. It's a question of our faith, honour and patriotism,"

after protesters laid siege on the national highway, has been pitch-forked into dealing with an unenviable law and order problem, facing swarms of protesters led by women and children, holding the tri-colour and shouting patriotic slogans.

Patil and the 18-party delegation got a first-hand experience of the public mood when they visited the curfew-bound Jammu on August 9. While Patil was closeted in Raj Bhavan, lending an ear to diametrically opposite and often clashing views of the leaders from Jammu and the Valley, the high-security complex reverberated with rooftop protests by residents of the adjoining, posh Karan Nagar locality. Despite curfew restrictions and concertina wire obstacles that have sprung up at all road openings in Jammu to prevent outpouring of demonstrators, the protests remained unabated.

The Centre's much-belated initiative of opening channels of communication with the samiti—a suggestion the BJP proffered when Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and Congress President Sonia



"In such a surcharged atmosphere, Valley politicians dare not campaign in Jammu and vice versa."

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